Songs of Thanks: Musicians Play for Hospitalized Veterans

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Dante Ciolfi unzips his guitar case in a courtyard of the Veterans Medical Center in Washington, D.C. 'I'm about to tune my guitar,' he says. He is getting ready to play some songs for patients in the hospital's **hospice** wing.

Ciolfi is a volunteer musician with Musicians On Call, a nonprofit that brings live music to hospital patients across the country, both at the bedside and by video call. The group's **motto** is 'delivering the healing power of music.' When Ciolfi is not volunteering, he teaches computer science to graduate students.

He meets up with Ellen Morris, another volunteer, who trains musician volunteers on hospital rules and guides them from room to room. At the **hospice** unit, Morris takes the lead and knocks on a patient's door. 'Hi there, how are you doing today? My name is Ellen with Musicians on Call,' she says. 'I have my friend Dante here that would love to play a song for you today, would that be OK?'

The patient, 93-year-old Army veteran Lawrence Ludden, agrees. He is sitting in his room reading the newspaper, but he is quick to extend his hand to visitors. Ciolfi thanks Ludden for the sacrifices he has made, then adjusts his guitar and begins singing 'Desperado,' by the Eagles. Ludden's room is filled with sunlight, and his daughter Eillen Ludden is there on her daily visit.

Ludden is the father of four, and his shelf is full of family pictures five grandchildren, two great-grandchildren, a picture of him and his late wife on their wedding day, and a couple of pictures of Ludden with England's Prince Harry, who visited the VA this past August. Once the song ends, Ludden claps and thanks the volunteers, smiling. He shares a memory, too. 'When I was a young boy I played piano, I used to like to sing quite a bit on the stage and I was in some **light operas**,' he says. 'You never told me that,' Morris replies.

The volunteers move on to the next room. Ciolfi plays 'Little Wonders,' by Rob Thomas, for Marine veteran John Fay, who is in bed and cannot speak. Fay taps his heart with his hand as he listens. 'To me that signals that he felt the music,' says Nicolette Rubin, a music **therapist** in charge of the music program at the VA Medical Center. She says music is not only uplifting to the spirit, but a restorative treatment that helps patients recover from and cope with emotional and physical trauma.

Air Force veteran Sidney Nichols whispers yes when Morris asks if he wants to listen to music. He served as a **pararescue** specialist for four years in Southeast Asia, including in Thailand, Vietnam, and the Philippines. Nichols is in bed, his eyes half-closed, but when Ciolfi starts singing 'Crazy Love,' by Van Morrison, he perks up and taps his hand on his leg as he silently begins mouthing the lyrics. 'You know that song, don't you? You were singing along,' Morris says. Nichols responds, 'I like it.' Since this story was reported, Sidney Nichols has died.

Ciolfi says he does not read the patients' charts, even though he could. 'I don't know

anything about their circumstances,' he says. 'I want to stay focused on the music.' When he plays, he tries to 'mentally establish a **conduit**, so the energy is kind of flowing back and forth. And to me that is so special... that energy is powerful.' Morris says she knew Ciolfi was perfect for the mission the first time she watched him play and saw him moved by a patient's reaction.

Musicians On Call volunteers have performed for more than a million patients across the country since the organization was founded in 1999. Volunteers typically go into hospitals three to four times a month. 'I appreciate the opportunity to do it. You know, to me it's a gift,' Ciolfi says. His immigrant parents came from Italy, and he says they taught him how lucky he is to be a U.S. citizen. 'Every single day I'm experiencing freedoms that other countries have no concept of,' he says freedoms he says are protected by veterans. 'If I can do one tiny thing like play a song, my gosh, I'm there.'

Word Treasure

hospice -- A hospice is a place where people who are very ill get care and comfort.

pararescue -- A pararescue specialist is a member of the Air Force trained to rescue people in danger.

therapist -- A music therapist is a trained person who uses music to help people feel better.

conduit -- A conduit is a channel that lets something flow through it.

motto -- A motto is a short phrase that sums up what a group believes in.

light operas -- Light operas are cheerful plays with singing.

Background you need

Musicians On Call is a nonprofit group that sends volunteer musicians into hospitals to play live music for patients, families, and caregivers.

A hospice wing is a part of a hospital where people who are very ill receive care focused on comfort.

Music therapy uses music to help patients cope with emotional and physical pain and to lift their spirits.

Veterans are people who served in the armed forces, and Veterans Day is a day to thank them for their service.

Break it down

LEAD: Volunteer musician Dante Ciolfi brings his guitar to the Veterans Medical Center in Washington, D.C., to play for patients.

KEY EVENT: Ciolfi and guide Ellen Morris visit patients in the hospice wing, playing songs bedside.

+- WHO: Army veteran Lawrence Ludden, Marine veteran John Fay, and Air Force veteran Sidney Nichols

+- WHAT: Live songs such as 'Desperado,' 'Little Wonders,' and 'Crazy Love'

+- WHEN: On a recent afternoon at the DC VA Medical Center

EVIDENCE: Fay taps his heart as he listens; Nichols perks up and mouths the lyrics; Ludden claps and smiles.

OPEN QUESTION: How can music keep helping patients recover and cope?

Why it matters

Music can comfort people who are hurting and help them feel connected, which matters for patients and for the veterans who served their country.

Test what you remember

1. What is Musicians On Call?

- (A) A nonprofit that brings live music to hospital patients
- (B) A company that sells guitars
- (C) A school for music teachers
- (D) A band that plays in concert halls

2. What song did Dante Ciolfi sing for Lawrence Ludden?

- (A) 'Desperado' by the Eagles
- (B) 'Desperado' by Van Morrison
- (C) 'Crazy Love' by Van Morrison
- (D) 'Little Wonders' by Rob Thomas

3. How did Marine veteran John Fay react to the music?

- (A) He tapped his heart with his hand
- (B) He fell asleep
- (C) He asked them to leave
- (D) He sang along loudly

4. What did Sidney Nichols do when he heard 'Crazy Love'?

- (A) He perked up, tapped his leg, and mouthed the lyrics
- (B) He asked for a different song
- (C) He told the musicians about his childhood
- (D) He went back to reading the newspaper

5. How many patients has Musicians On Call performed for since 1999?

- (A) More than ten thousand
- (B) More than a thousand
- (C) More than a hundred
- (D) More than a million

6. What did Ciolfi say about playing a song for veterans?

- (A) 'I only play for veterans on holidays.'
- (B) 'If I can do one tiny thing like play a song, my gosh, I'm there.'
- (C) 'Hospitals should hire full-time bands.'
- (D) 'I want to become a famous singer.'

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: A 3: A 4: A 5: D 6: B

Questions to think about

1. Dante Ciolfi, volunteer musician: Says playing for veterans is profound and a gift, and that he tries to hold emotional space for each patient.

2. Nicolette Rubin, music therapist: Says music uplifts the spirit and helps patients recover from and cope with emotional and physical trauma.

3. Ellen Morris, volunteer guide: Says Ciolfi was perfect for the mission after watching him moved by a patient's reaction.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):